divine peerage. "It's a deeply important intervention, artistically. I get the feeling he's responding to an inner artistic restlessness. It's possible for you to be dissatisfied with a craft you've already mastered and bored with the world of beautiful *poomalais*," says Subramanian. In her view, he was "experimenting with form as part of his political curiosity" and, consequently, produced some formalistically brilliant work, like the Afghan Church concert with Vikku Vinayakram. "He was setting a new discourse by rehabilitating the *upapakkavadyam* (the ghatam, a 'lesser' accompaniment). And his interventions have indeed succeeded in opening Carnatic to new audiences," she says.

But it also ruffled a deeply internalised—and widely disseminated—image of Carnatic as a "pure", hermetically sealed-off aesthetic universe, untouched by other castes and geographies, and especially immune to the Persianate influence so visible on Hindustani. In the more calendar pop-art tellings, it has an immaculate conception, a magical leap of faith from Vedic incantations to its trinity of great composers, via a couple of millennia of Brahmin musical treatises. Even *Encyclopaedia Britannica* trots out this bowdlerised myth. How valid is it? Not very, judging from facts always in plain sight as also fresh evidence.

Scholars evoke a field marked at its core by heterogeneity. "Krishna's interventions are crucial because they gesture back at well-documented historical fact," says Katherine Schofield, head of the music department at King's College London. "The idea that Carnatic is 'pure' or a bulwark against 'foreign' influences from the North, Persia, or indeed anywhere else has never been true. It has always rubbed shoulders with, and borrowed from, Hindustani raga traditions, as well as a wide range of other musics." Even as it began to diverge as a species in the 16th century and matured by the 18th—around new classificatory codes for ragas, a recognisable rhythmic language, its own song repertoire—she says its performers and patrons still reflected a much broader caste/religion spectrum than would be visible after the 'modern' reforms of the late 19th-20th centuries. That process was to soak it all up into a monoculture, with illustrious exceptions like Subbulakshmi proving the rule with a symbolic migration to the ingroup.

Follow just one trail from the rather more miscegenated old world: Somanatha's 1609 treatise *Ragavibodha*, written in Vijayanagara and a key text in Carnatic's prehistory, names 11 Persian maqams. When a violin maestro bows into Thyagaraja's invocatory *Rama Ninne Namminaanu*,



"It's still an individual act of transgression by a Brahmin.... Sometimes it feels like we are caught in the cross-fire of someone else's conflict"

–MEENA KANDASAMY
Poet, caste activist

what emanates from the magic lamp is a transnational genie: one of those "*parasikeya*" maqams, Huseni, that too on a western instrument. Indeed, in reconstructions by scholars like Davesh Soneji, even 18th-century Tanjore—that buzzing natal ward of Carnatic—emerges as a truly cosmopolitan space of thick cultural exchange. Its aesthete-kings are Maratha Bhonsles from Shivaji's cadet line—this works more like a bridge than a fortress. Besides the southern linguistic-artistic concourse, present in court are Hindustani musicians from Gwalior, the other end of the Maratha confederacy. "Hindustani music was widely performed and patronised in Vijayanagara, in Tipu's Mysore, in Arcot, even late-colonial Madras," says Schofield. At Tanjore, the audiences comprise visiting colonial grandees. Local musicians learn the piano. India's first brass band is born. The courtesan dance-form reaches virtuosic heights, suffused in the eroticism later excised by Bharatanatyam. It's at this buzzing Early Modern crossroads, conscious of an overarching civilisational challenge posed by the world, that the trinity composes its masterworks. Unlike Hindustani, its renderings are tightly bound to compositional text, reminiscent of western art music. Among its more playful gestures: Muthuswamy Dikshithar's shelf full of western-inspired 'nottuswaram' (literally: 'note note') pieces. And among his northern souvenirs is another piece of Persian delight: Emaan (Yaman) Kalyan, renamed Yamuna Kalyani. *Krishna Nee Begane Baro*? Not a moment too soon.

"That curated, manufactured self-image, which collapses Carnatic with pious Brahminhood and its divinised materials, has long been there. But its choreography has intensified in the last decade, with a heavy diasporic investment in reinvoking tradition, mirroring a larger politics," says Subramanian. The present burst of verbal artillery too is curated and performative rage. The Academy backed Krishna adeptly, but the protesters were clearly enacting the old rituals of excommunication in a modern political context. If Krishna is an unabashed voice here, his critics are hardly unaffiliated—Ranjani-Gayatri, Ravikiran and the Trichur Brothers made effusive votive offerings for the January 22 ceremony at Ayodhya. But that's only a transitional context. On a more enduring, unfolding canvas for Carnatic, Krishna will perhaps not be seen as an antithesis but as a necessary internal self-correction. Outside, Kandasamy confesses to bemusement: "Sometimes it feels like we are caught in the cross-fire of someone else's conflict." The song is unfinished till it crosses that bridge to 'someone else'. ■